

GE261004 DESIGN THINKING

Unit II – Empathy and Problem Definition · Presentation 6 of 6

Point of View Statements and Reframing

The POV template · needs are verbs · testing a POV · what reframing is · four ways to reframe · when to do it

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In this presentation

- The POV template
- The three parts
- Needs are verbs, not nouns
- Testing your POV
- What reframing is
- Reframes from Unit I
- Four ways to reframe
- When to reframe



1

The point of view

One sentence that carries everything you learned

The POV template

USER

a specific person,
not 'people'

needs

NEED

a verb — something
they need to do

because

INSIGHT

why it matters — what
you learned in the field

A first-year student who commutes two hours

needs a place to work between classes, because going home
and coming back costs her the whole evening.

Three parts, one sentence — and the insight is the part you had to go out to find.

The three parts

USER

One person, described specifically enough that you would recognise them in a corridor.

NEED

Something they must be able to do. Always a verb, never a product.

INSIGHT

The reason the need exists – the thing you learned that nobody had assumed.

KEY POINT The insight is the part you could not have written before going out. If you could have, you have not finished.

Needs are verbs, not nouns

- “Needs a handrail” is a solution; “needs to feel steady on the stairs” is a need
- A verb keeps the solution space open; a noun closes it before you start
- Test it: can you name three completely different ways to meet it?
- Write the need in the user's terms, not in engineering terms

KEY POINT The moment a noun enters the need, ideation is over before it began.

Testing your POV

- Would the user recognise themselves in it, and agree the need is real?
- Does it contain an insight you did not have two weeks ago?
- Does it suggest at least five genuinely different directions?
- Can a stranger read it and start designing without asking you a question?

KEY POINT Read it to someone outside the team. If they ask “so what is the actual problem?”, it is not finished.

2

Reframing

Restating the problem so different answers become visible

What reframing is

- Deliberately restating the problem so a different set of answers becomes possible
- Not a failure of the first frame – it is how the process is meant to work
- Triggered by field evidence, a failed prototype, or a constraint you cannot move
- Every case study in Unit I turned on exactly one reframe

KEY POINT The reframe is usually the moment a project becomes worth doing at all.

Reframes from Unit I

Case	First frame	Reframed as
Embrace	A cheaper incubator	Keep a newborn warm with no mains power
Aravind	Better cataract surgery	Far more surgeries at a price people can pay
Jaipur Foot	A cheaper prosthetic	A foot for squatting and wet fields
MittiCool	A cheaper refrigerator	Keep food fresh with no electricity

Four ways to reframe

Zoom out

Ask what larger problem this one is a symptom of. The queue may really be a scheduling problem.

Zoom in

Take one moment of the experience and treat that single moment as the whole problem.

Flip it

State the opposite and see what it reveals: how might we make them want to wait?

Change the actor

Give the job to somebody else. What if the user did it instead of the staff?

When to reframe

- When every idea your team generates turns out to be the same idea
- When the field evidence keeps contradicting the brief you were given
- When a prototype fails for a reason nobody had considered
- When the constraint you keep hitting turns out to be the real subject

KEY POINT Reframe early, while it is cheap. Once something has been built, the cost of reframing rises steeply.

In class: reframe another team's problem

- Write your team's POV in one sentence on a single sheet
- Pass it to the next team; they write two reframes of it
- Take it back and either adopt one or defend the original
- Rewrite and pin it up – this is what Unit III will ideate against

ACTIVITY Twenty minutes. Every team leaves with one POV statement and at least one considered alternative to it.

THINK ABOUT IT

Which of your team's constraints have you been treating as fixed – and what if it is the actual problem?

- Which constraint have you never questioned out loud?
- Who imposed it, and when was that decided?
- What becomes possible if it disappears?
- What would you have to find out to challenge it?

Summary

- A POV carries one user, a verb-shaped need and an earned insight
- Needs are verbs; a noun closes the solution space immediately
- A finished POV lets a stranger start designing without asking you
- Reframing restates the problem so new answers become visible
- Zoom out, zoom in, flip it, change the actor
- Reframe early – after building, the cost rises steeply

Next: Unit III – Ideation and Creative Thinking

- Idea generation techniques and brainstorming
- Mind mapping and the SCAMPER technique
- Lateral thinking and the Six Thinking Hats
- Concept selection and evaluating feasibility